GENDER BENDERS

Vivian Khanna vs Debashree Chakraborty

Making the mouse left-handed

25 sec

A cricket pro keen on studying business management, Vivian is equally adept at using computers. He volunteers to go first and actually smirks when we tell him about the task at hand. Vivian double-clicks ‘My Computer’, accessing the Control Panel. He double-clicks the ‘Mouse’ icon there, and takes a look at the ‘Mouse Properties’ dialog box. Under ‘Options’, Vivian selects ‘Switch primary and secondary buttons’ and clicks ‘Apply’. Now that’s a job well done!

1 min 5 sec

A literature lover and biotech student, Debashree is cheerful and excited. She takes her seat and, soon enough, clicks the Start Menu. Next, she goes to ‘Settings’, then ‘Control Panel’, and clicks the ‘Keyboard’ icon—bummer! Debashree hunts awhile and realises she’s in the wrong place. She hurries back to the Control Panel, and this time clicks the ‘Mouse’ icon. Then, soon enough, she does what’s needed. Debashree couldn’t match Vivian’s timing, but it’s still good going, girl!

Frankfurt, Germany, and Colorado, USA, in addition to the two locations in Japan. By selecting the preferred time zone using the World Time function and receiving radio signals from Japan, Europe, or the United States, users can enjoy using a watch that boasts of a superior accuracy of about one second in a 100,000 (one lakh) years.

Seiko Watch Corporation plans to put a radio-controlled watch model installed with this newly-developed movement on the domestic Japanese market in September.

Junghans also plans to offer a radio-controlled watch model installed with a slightly altered version of this newly developed movement primarily in Europe in the future.

So, what time is that talk show in Frankfurt, again?

JAWS IV?

SHARK: Your New Keyboard

Well, okay, it’s no shark attack. But for a smartphone user, it’s no less either! Imagine being able to do away with those never-ending searches for letters and saving your fingers the trouble of punching in endless text. It may not be long before you can input data into your smartphone using a space-age Etch-a-Sketch. IBM has created an experimental keyboard system that lets users write by ‘connecting the dots’, as it were.

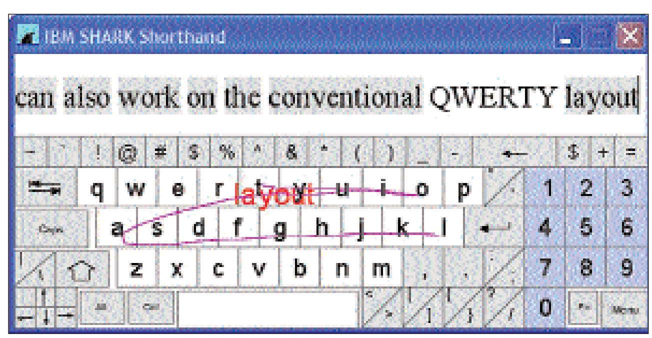
SHARK (Shorthand-Aided Rapid Keyboarding) is an advanced pen-based shorthand method that allows users to input words into mobile devices by tracing them letter-by-letter on a virtual keyboard. Instead of tapping independently on four virtual keys with a stylus to spell ‘word’, users would put the stylus on ‘W’ and then carve a continuous trail all the way to ‘D’.

Users initially hunt for letters to write words, but the idea is that they fairly rapidly start to memorise the shape of common words and word components—and therefore, their dependence on visual guidance decreases. The computer assesses the user’s final pattern, interprets it as a word from its database, and turns it into text on the screen.

SHARK, which has been in beta mode since October 2004, remains a lab project. The growing popularity of smartphones is prompting researchers and companies to develop input systems that will work optimally with those devices.

People have adapted to the QWERTY keyboard, but these are generally too large to tote around with mobile devices. Some companies have come out with projection keyboards that project a laser image of a QWERTY board. The keyboards are light, but require a flat, even surface—not very easy to come by when you’re travelling.

According to IBM, SHARK also takes care of the speech and handwriting recognition problems faced by today’s software. In trial runs, a few users achieved speeds of around 16 to 17 words per minute! Though this is far slower than touch typing, it is definitely faster than using a stylus on your palmtop.



Buzzword of the MONTH

Perpendicular Recording

Data recording on disks is currently done ‘longitudinally’. However, the amount of data that can be stored in this manner is fast reaching its limit. Perpendicular recording is being touted as the successor to longitudinal recording.

While longitudinal recording works in a single plane parallel to the disk surface, perpendicular recording works at right angles to the disk surface, piling bits on top of each other. As the name indicates, longitudinal recording aligns data bits horizontally, parallel to the surface of the disk. In contrast, perpendicular recording aligns the bits vertically, perpendicular to the disk, which allows additional room on a disk to pack more data, thus enabling higher recording densities. So far, a 10 GB microdrive has been designed using this technology.